thing, but suspension is certainly worth considering'. The two of them were clearly patting each other on the back. Together they were working through a process of helping each other out from their respective predicaments. In the process they stitched up Bhagat Singh. So long as they could create the impression that they had done all that they could, that was all that mattered.

The truth is that at no stage did Mahatma Gandhi insist that the need of the hour was the release of Bhagat Singh. The political agreement in the Gandhi–Irwin Pact was reached on 5 March 1931. Bhagat Singh went to the gallows eighteen days later on 23 March 1931. At no stage did Gandhi say to Irwin that a price for the agreement reached at that time was not the suspension, but the commutation of the sentence of death passed on the three young men in the Lahore Conspiracy Case. Yet, Gandhi happily went on thereafter to participate in the Second Round Table Conference which started six months later in London on 7 September 1931. If the Mahatma in the Gandhi-Irwin Pact was able to ask for the release of tens of thousands of prisoners who had been involved in the non-cooperation movement, he could also have asked for the release of Bhagat Singh on death row. That he did not venture to do so is a damning indictment of the Mahatma. To this day, there are people who hold him singularly responsible. In fact if truth be told, Gandhi's efforts on behalf of Bhagat Singh were next to nothing. His efforts serve only to show his cynicism. We know this because while speaking about Bhagat Singh to Irwin, he needlessly condemns him with the words, 'He is undoubtedly a brave man but I would certainly say that he is not in his right mind.'[16] Why would anyone want to save a person who is not in his right mind? In fact, anyone with a scintilla of knowledge of what Bhagat Singh believed in and stood for in his life in revolution would not use these words while asking for clemency from the viceroy. Still less would he have described him as such to the viceroy because to do so was to show him as being less than human and to diminish his humanity. To crown it all, Gandhi then told the viceroy, 'I am putting this matter before you as a humanitarian issue . . . in order that there may not be unnecessary turmoil in the country. *I would not take it ill even if you do not give any reply to this issue*.'(emphases added)[17] Is that how one pleads for a person's life? That